

The numbers are still “ballpark.” The school is not.

After more than a year of budget warnings, consultants and committee work, MUSD's Sept. 10 hearing showed how much of the Landers closure case is still unfinished - and why the fight has become a test of governance as much as finance.

The room came prepared for a decision about a small rural school. What it got instead was a three-hour argument over what counts as a complete decision.

District officials presented a recognizable case: MUSD enrollment has fallen from its 2006 peak; Landers is far smaller than it once was; small campuses create staffing and program constraints; and larger schools may concentrate specialists and reduce combination classes.

Parents, employees and longtime residents did not deny the fiscal problem. Their challenge was different: **if closure is permanent, why is the net financial model still incomplete?**

That question became harder to dismiss when a district response described the numbers currently before the public as “**ballpark.**” The district also said more analysis remains, funds would need to be invested before consolidation could occur, and a deeper analysis requested by the Board is expected in October.

The hearing therefore changed the center of gravity. The debate is no longer only whether Landers is small. It is whether the district has finished the work necessary to prove that closing it is the best available choice.

THE LINE THAT DEFINED THE NIGHT

“I would say [the numbers] are **ballpark.**”

DISTRICT RESPONSE
2:43:34-2:43:38

WHAT THIS REPORT DOES

Separates the district's case from the community's case, identifies what the hearing established, and lists what remains unanswered before any irreversible decision.

Transcript caution: the source audio is muffled in places. Quotations are used only where wording is reasonably clear from the working SRT. Garbled place names and obvious transcription errors are normalized only when context makes the intended term clear. Verify against the video before external verbatim publication.

AT A GLANCE

3 personnel tiers. +3 bus routes. More receiving-site analysis still pending. Board-requested deeper analysis expected in October.

THE CORE TENSION

The district proved Landers is small. The hearing did not prove that closing it is the best completed option.

First came the deficit. Then the study. Then the recommendation.

The closure debate did not begin at Landers. It grew out of a districtwide fiscal and enrollment problem - and a public process that produced a recommendation to try alternatives first.

LATE 2025

Fiscal stabilization and declining enrollment move to the center of district planning. MUSD engages School Leaders for budget analysis and support.

JAN.-MAY 2026

Enrollment/7-11 Committee meets publicly. It reviews enrollment, facilities, fiscal data, transportation, staffing and five consolidation scenarios.

MAY / JUNE 2026

The committee finalizes its recommendation. It asks the Board to pursue alternative fiscal efficiencies before closing campuses.

JUNE 9

Committee report reaches the Board. Its formal recommendation says closures should remain a measure of last resort.

AUG. 25

Closure scenarios return. Landers is examined for consolidation into Yucca Mesa and personnel-savings tiers are presented.

SEPT. 10

Landers public hearing. The room presses for the complete net model, receiving-site plan and accounting of what happened to the committee recommendations.

THE COMMITTEE'S FORMAL LANGUAGE

“School closures should remain a measure of last resort...”

The report said MUSD should demonstrate that viable enrollment, retention and operational-efficiency strategies have been fully implemented and evaluated before irreversible closures, and recommended the district refrain from closing schools while alternatives are pursued.

WHY THAT MATTERS NOW

The committee's recommendation was advisory; the Board retains final authority. But the recommendation created a public benchmark: **alternatives first, closure last.**

At the hearing, the sharpest governance exchange came when community members said a response about “recommendations” was describing School Leaders rather than the Enrollment Committee.

“That was School Leaders though. She wants to know the 7-11 Committee's recommendations.”

Working transcript, approx. 2:47:35.

THE COMMITTEE'S THREE FORMAL DIRECTIONS

1. Rebalance boundaries.

Adjust elementary boundaries districtwide.

2. Closure last.

Implement and evaluate viable enrollment, retention and efficiency strategies first.

3. Rural funding advocacy.

Pursue ADA and rural-funding changes better suited to a geographically large district.

A smaller district operating the same number of elementary schools

MUSD's strongest argument is structural: enrollment fell, the elementary footprint did not, and very small schools can be expensive and hard to staff.

7,400

district students in 1986
7 elementary schools

9,700

district students in 2006
11 elementary schools

7,300

district students cited for 2026
11 elementary schools

THE HISTORICAL FRAME

At the hearing, district leadership used a long-range comparison to explain why consolidation is back on the table. The district said it had roughly 7,400 students and seven elementary schools in 1986. By 2006 enrollment had grown to roughly 9,700 and the elementary system to 11 schools. In 2026, officials said enrollment was back near 7,300 while the district still operated 11 elementary campuses.

LANDERS IN THAT FRAME

The presentation cited 223 students at Landers in 2005, 143 in 2018 and 107 in 2026. That long-range decline is the district's clearest quantitative reason for examining sustainability.

SCALE AND STAFFING

A district presenter said **400-450 students** is considered an optimal elementary size for comparable high-desert settings, while acknowledging geography makes that target impossible everywhere.

Staff also emphasized combination classes. The presentation said Landers went from five combination classes in 2025-26 to three in 2026-27, and that reducing combination classes requires more staffing.

BALANCED READING

The district did establish a legitimate policy question: how many very small schools can MUSD sustain while preserving programs and staffing? What it did **not** settle at the hearing is whether closing Landers is the least harmful and most cost-effective answer to that question.

Hearing transcript references: historical enrollment and school counts approx. 1:21:20-1:22:16; Landers enrollment approx. 1:22:24-1:23:04; "400 to 450" optimal-size discussion approx. 1:27:00; combination classes approx. 1:34:29-1:35:48.

WHAT SIZE DOES NOT ANSWER

A school can be inefficient at one scale and still be the least harmful option after transportation, family access and receiving-site costs are counted.

WHAT THE BOARD STILL HAS TO DECIDE

Not whether Landers is small, but whether its closure produces enough net benefit to justify a permanent community loss.

Small is not the same thing as disposable

Parents and staff answered the district's efficiency argument with a site-specific one: Landers serves unusually high-need students, transportation is already difficult, and the school is showing measurable improvement.

87.1%

socioeconomically disadvantaged

12.9%

homeless - 18 students

15.1%

students with disabilities

A SCHOOL WITH HIGH NEED

The Landers multi-year profile compiled from district SPSA documents shows a population with substantial economic and housing instability. Those figures matter because transportation, attendance and continuity are not abstract issues for families already facing barriers.

A SCHOOL WITH IMPROVING ATTENDANCE

Chronic absenteeism in the profile moved from 34.5% to 29.7% to 25.9% across reported years. Academics remain mixed, but the profile notes gains in targeted areas including writing and research/inquiry.

“Students aren't just numbers. They're people.”

STUDENT SPEAKER - WORDING SHOULD BE CHECKED AGAINST VIDEO BEFORE PUBLICATION

THE RURAL FACTOR

Repeated testimony described unpaved roads, long driving distances, work schedules and informal pickup networks. The community's claim is not that transportation makes closure impossible; it is that a districtwide efficiency model can shift significant cost and time onto families in a way the district ledger does not show.

STAFF CHALLENGED THE GENERIC “SMALL SCHOOL” MODEL

Landers employees argued that the campus already covers many of the programs district presenters described as harder to provide at small schools. One teacher told the room the school had programming covered despite staffing reductions and combination classes.

“A decision that saves money for the district should not cause greater hardship for the families that it serves.”

Community speaker, approx. 0:12:15-0:12:23.

ACCESS

“Our school is full with participation because they can get here.”

Landers staff member, ~2:53:09

TEAM

“Team Landers, these educators are killing it.”

Speaker at hearing, ~2:08:26

Gross savings are easy to print. Net savings are the decision.

The district published three Landers personnel-savings tiers. The hearing made clear that those figures are only one side of the closure ledger.

\$368,512

Landers Tier 1
personnel savings

\$629,378

Landers Tier 2
personnel savings

\$908,176

Landers Tier 3
personnel savings

WHAT IS OFFICIAL

MUSD's personnel-savings table gives three different annual figures depending on the level of staff reduction. The official transportation scenario for Landers consolidation also changes combined Landers/Yucca Mesa transportation from **6 routes to 9**.

Those are real inputs. They are not yet one net number.

6 → 9

combined bus routes under the district's Landers-to-Yucca Mesa scenario

WHAT THE PUBLIC ASKED FOR

Parents repeatedly asked for a line-item model that includes transportation, receiving-school staffing, facility work, transition costs and enrollment loss.

At approximately 2:43:23, a parent asked when the public would see the numbers showing what would be spent and saved in the move.

“The numbers that you're looking at right now are... I would say are **ballpark.**”

District response, approx. 2:43:34-2:43:38.

THE KEY DISTINCTION

The district has numbers. The stronger criticism is that the district has not yet presented one complete, decision-grade net model tying those numbers together.

A DECISION-GRADE NET MODEL SHOULD SHOW, ON ONE PAGE

Recurring savings

Positions actually removed from district payroll.

Recurring new costs

Buses, staffing, services, security and receiving-site operations.

One-time + risk

Facility work, transition, enrollment attrition and implementation timing.

Closing Landers is only half the plan. Yucca Mesa is the other half.

A consolidation cannot be evaluated only by what leaves Landers. It must also be evaluated by what Yucca Mesa has to absorb - students, buses, staff, programs, traffic and facility investment.

WHAT THE HEARING ESTABLISHED

During the receiving-site discussion, a district response said there was **“still analysis to be done before anything like this could be possible”** and that funds would have to be invested before the option could proceed.

The next sentence in the SRT is badly garbled, but context strongly suggests the speaker was discussing Yucca Mesa's readiness to receive Landers students. Because the audio is unclear, this report does not treat the garbled sentence as a verbatim quote.

“There's still analysis to be done before anything like this could be possible.”

DISTRICT RESPONSE, APPROX. 1:56:21-1:56:27

The same response added that the Board could ultimately determine the option was “a bigger hurdle than we had expected.”

THE SEPT. 22 FRAME

Do not ask Yucca Mesa only whether it can “fit” Landers. Ask what the school must change, what it will cost, and what current Yucca Mesa families gain or lose.

THE RECEIVING-SCHOOL CHECKLIST

- 1 How many classrooms are available without creating new combinations or crowding?
- 2 Which Landers staff transfer, which positions disappear and which new receiving-site positions are needed?
- 3 What special-education, intervention and mental-health capacity must be added?
- 4 What traffic and pickup/drop-off changes are required?
- 5 What is the annual cost of the three additional bus routes?
- 6 What one-time facility work is needed before students move?
- 7 Which programs improve because of consolidation - specifically, not theoretically?
- 8 What happens if a portion of Landers families leave MUSD instead?

DISTRICT CAUTION

The option may turn out to be “a bigger hurdle than we had expected.”

District response, ~1:56:58-1:57:10

WHY SEPT. 22 MATTERS

Yucca Mesa families can test the proposal from the receiving side: what changes for their classrooms, staffing, traffic and programs?

When the public starts doing the institution's homework

The Landers fight has evolved from opposition to a closure into a broader argument about how decisions are built, checked and explained.

Parents have spent months requesting records, reading budgets and SPSAs, bringing outside databases into meetings, comparing administrative spending, questioning consultants and tracking Board actions. A Landers parent also contacted the California Attorney General; the complaint was forwarded to the Bureau of Children's Justice. No MUSD investigation has been announced.

Community members also raised a Brown Act concern over compensation actions and pursued the formal Cure and Correct process. Whatever one's view of those disputes, the pattern matters politically: citizens are no longer merely reacting to agendas. They are auditing the process.

“This is no longer just a budget problem. It's a crisis of trust and governance.”

COMMUNITY COMMENT, APPROX. 0:45:31

THE COMMITTEE EXCHANGE

Near the end of the hearing, a response about recommendations prompted a correction from the audience:

“You're regurgitating School Leaders' recommendations. Can you tell us the 7-11 Committee's recommendations, please?”

Approx. 2:47:38-2:47:47.

After the subsequent explanation, another voice said:

“You should have that memorized.”

Approx. 2:48:26.

POSITION CONTROL IS STILL UNDERWAY

Later, district staff said a comprehensive position-control review was in progress and described it as going “position by position.” That matters because community members are asking why school closure is advancing while central-office options are still being evaluated.

WHAT THE DISTRICT CAN FAIRLY SAY

Modern compliance, reporting and service requirements can require administrative capacity that did not exist decades ago. A raw comparison of headcount across eras is not enough.

WHAT THE PUBLIC CAN FAIRLY ASK

If school closure and management structure are both being reviewed as fiscal tools, the Board should see both options with comparable dollar totals before choosing the irreversible one.

STILL UNDERWAY

District staff said the position-control review is going “position by position.”

THE GOVERNANCE TEST

If multiple cost-saving paths are still being developed, the Board can compare them before selecting the one that cannot easily be reversed.

The case is not finished. The next questions should be.

The Sept. 10 hearing did not produce a closure decision. It produced a list of work that still has to be completed - and a clearer standard for what the public should demand before the Board acts.

BEFORE AN IRREVERSIBLE DECISION

- 1 Publish one line-item net model.** Not just staffing tiers: recurring savings after all new recurring costs, plus one-time transition costs.
- 2 Publish the Yucca Mesa receiving plan.** Capacity, staffing, special education, programs, traffic, buses, facility work and timeline.
- 3 Publish attrition scenarios.** Show what happens financially if 5%, 10% or 20% of Landers families leave MUSD.
- 4 Publish an implementation matrix for the Enrollment Committee recommendations.** What was tried, when, at what cost, with what measurable result?
- 5 Publish the equity-impact analysis.** Identify who bears longer trips, transition risk and access burdens.
- 6 Put central-office options on the same page.** The district says position control is underway; show the Board the options and savings before choosing closure.

“Closing a school is forever.”

COMMUNITY SPEAKER, APPROX. 0:08:58

NEXT CHECKPOINTS

Sept. 22 - Yucca Mesa hearing

Shift the focus to receiving-site readiness, cost and impact.

Oct. 13 - Board meeting

The Sept. 10 exchange referenced a more in-depth analysis being provided at the October meeting.

THE STRONGEST POST-HEARING FORMULATION

MUSD has estimates. What the public still needs is the completed decision model.

That is more precise - and harder to rebut - than saying the district “has no numbers.”

“We are the ones who remain here. Our children remain here. Our community remains here.”

Community comment, approx. 0:47:10.

Sources and method. Sept. 10, 2026 Landers public-hearing working transcript; MUSD Enrollment/7-11 Committee Final Report (June 2026); MUSD Enrollment Committee Review / Aug. 25 transportation and consolidation materials; MUSD personnel-savings table; Landers multi-year profile compiled from district SPSA documents. This report distinguishes official district figures from community interpretation. Because the hearing recording is muffled, quotations should be checked against the original video before use as verbatim press quotes.